



ALL-AFRICA STUDENTS UNION
UNION PANAFRICAINE DES ETUDIANTS
UNIÃO DOS ESTUDANTES DE TODA A ÁFRICA
اتحاد طلاب عموم إفريقيا



Ministry of Foreign Affairs
Republic of Ghana

REPORT ON THE AASU HANDING-OVER, INAUGURATION AND HONOURS CEREMONY



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CONVENED BY:



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SUBMITTED TO:



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FOREWORD BY THE AASU SECRETARY GENERAL

On behalf of the All-Africa Students Union (AASU), I am pleased to present this report on the Handing-Over, Inauguration and Honours Ceremony held on 30 January 2026 at the Press Centre of the Ministry of Foreign Affairs, Accra. The ceremony marked an important milestone in the institutional life of AASU, formally transitioning leadership to the newly elected Executive Committee for the 2026–2029 term, while recognising individuals and institutions whose support has strengthened the African student movement.

I wish to express the Union's deep appreciation to the Ministry of Foreign Affairs of the Republic of Ghana for its leadership and support in hosting and facilitating this event. The Ministry's collaboration, including logistical support, and representation for the administration of the oath of office, was instrumental to the success of the ceremony and reaffirmed the strong partnership between AASU and the Government of Ghana. This partnership continues to reflect Ghana's longstanding commitment to Pan-Africanism, youth engagement, and continental cooperation.

The ceremony brought together over 500 participants from across Africa, including government officials, members of the diplomatic corps, representatives of continental and international organisations, development partners, civil society institutions, national student unions, and alumni of the student movement. Their presence underscored the relevance of AASU as a continental platform and the shared commitment to advancing students' rights, quality education, and constructive youth participation in governance and development.

I extend my sincere appreciation to our partners and stakeholders, whose collaboration and confidence continue to enable AASU's work. I also commend the AASU Secretariat and staff for their professionalism and dedication in organising the event, as well as the outgoing Executive Committee for their service and stewardship, which laid important foundations for the new administration.

As we commence the 2026–2029 leadership term, this ceremony reaffirmed our collective resolve to position students as strategic partners in Africa's education transformation. It is my hope that this report will serve not only as a formal record of the event, but also as a testament to the spirit of continuity, accountability, and partnership that defines the All-Africa Students Union.

Divine E. Kwadzodeh

Divine Edem Kwadzodeh
Secretary-General
All-Africa Students Union (AASU)



1.0 BACKGROUND AND PURPOSE OF THE CEREMONY

The All-Africa Students Union (AASU) is the continental umbrella body representing organised student movements across Africa. Since its establishment, AASU has served as a platform for advocacy, dialogue, and cooperation among African students, advancing the ideals of Pan-Africanism, quality education, democratic participation, and youth engagement in continental development processes.

The Republic of Ghana has played a historic and strategic role in the life of the Union. Since hosting the AASU Secretariat in Accra, Ghana has provided an enabling institutional environment that has strengthened the Union's legitimacy, continuity, and capacity to operate as a continental student organisation. This longstanding partnership reflects Ghana's enduring commitment to Pan-African solidarity and to the empowerment of Africa's youth and students.

The Handing-Over, Inauguration and Honours Ceremony was convened to formally mark the transition between the outgoing AASU leadership (2022–2025) and the newly elected Executive Committee for the 2026–2029 term. The ceremony also provided a platform to reaffirm AASU's mandate, to publicly inaugurate the new leadership, and to acknowledge the contributions of individuals and institutions that have supported the Union's work over the years.

Hosting the ceremony at the Press Centre of the Ministry of Foreign Affairs in Accra was both symbolic and strategic. It underscored the role of student diplomacy within Africa's broader foreign policy and Pan-African engagement framework and highlighted the recognition of AASU as a legitimate stakeholder in continental dialogue on education, youth development, and governance. The venue further reflected the strong partnership between AASU and the Government of Ghana, particularly in youth and student engagement.

The ceremony was further designed to recognise exceptional service and support through the conferment of honours and citations, including institutional appreciation to the Government and People of Ghana, and recognition of individuals who have contributed significantly to the advancement of students' rights and education transformation in Africa. It also served as an opportunity to reinforce AASU's strategic direction, articulated around the theme "Reimagining Africa's Education Future: Students as Partners in Reform and Delivery."

Overall, the Handing-Over, Inauguration and Honours Ceremony brought together over 500 participants from across the African continent, including government officials, diplomatic representatives, development partners, student leaders, and civil society actors. It reaffirmed AASU's commitment to continuity, accountability, and collaboration, while positioning the incoming leadership to advance the Union's work in partnership with governments, continental institutions, and stakeholders across Africa.

1.1 Event Overview

The All-Africa Students Union (AASU) Handing-Over, Inauguration and Honours Ceremony was held on Friday, 30 January 2026, at the Press Centre of the Ministry of Foreign Affairs, Accra, under the theme "Reimagining Africa's Education Future: Students as Partners in Reform and Delivery." The ceremony formally marked the transition from the outgoing AASU leadership (2022–2025) to the newly elected Executive Committee for the 2026–2029 term, while recognising the contributions of individuals and institutions to the advancement of students' rights and education transformation in Africa. Although key dignitaries, including John Dramani Mahama, President of the Republic of Ghana; Samuel Okudzeto Ablakwa, Minister of Foreign Affairs; and Mohamed Ibn Chambas, were unable to attend due to their participation in the High-Level Consultative Conference on Regional Cooperation and Security (29–30 January 2026), the Ministry of Foreign Affairs was duly represented by the Deputy Director of the Africa Bilateral Bureau, Mr. Wilson Adja-Kwesi, who also facilitated the administration of the oath of office for the newly inducted AASU executives. Convened in partnership with the Ministry, the event brought together over 500 participants from across the African continent, including government officials, members of the diplomatic corps, development partners, civil society organisations, and student leaders.

The programme featured the swearing-in of the new leadership, valedictory and inaugural addresses, the conferment of honours and citations, and reflections on AASU's historical legacy and future role in continental student engagement.



2.0 SPEECHES AND FORMALITIES

The All-Africa Students Union (AASU) Handing-Over, Inauguration and Honours Ceremony commenced promptly at the Press Centre of the Ministry of Foreign Affairs, Accra, with proceedings formally moderated by Mr. Samuel Sasu Adonteng, Chief Technical Officer of AASU, who served as Master of Ceremonies for the event. In his opening remarks, he welcomed participants and outlined the objectives of the ceremony, emphasising its significance as a moment of institutional transition, continuity, and renewed commitment to Pan-African student engagement.

In recognition of the Union's diversity and inclusivity, the opening session featured multi-faith prayers, reflecting the plural spiritual traditions represented within the African student community. A Christian prayer was led by a Reverend Minister, followed by an Islamic prayer delivered by Dr. Abubakar Mohammed, Personal Assistant to the National Chief Imam of Ghana. These invocations set a reflective and solemn tone for the proceedings and underscored AASU's respect for religious coexistence and unity.

This was followed by the rendition of the National Anthem of the Republic of Ghana, in acknowledgment of Ghana's role as host nation to the AASU Continental Secretariat and as a longstanding partner to the Union.

Subsequently, the Welcome Address was delivered by the Chief Operations Officer (COO) of AASU, who formally welcomed all dignitaries, guests, partners, and student leaders in attendance. In the address, the COO highlighted the significance of the occasion, noting the successful completion of the outgoing administration's tenure and the importance of the ceremony in inaugurating a new leadership mandate. The address also acknowledged the strategic support and cooperation of the Ministry of Foreign Affairs and other partners that have enabled AASU to operate effectively as a continental organisation.

The opening session concluded with the formal recognition of dignitaries and invited guests, including representatives of the Government of Ghana, the diplomatic corps, continental and international organisations, development partners, civil society institutions, national student unions, and the AASU Secretariat.

2.1 Valedictory Address by the Outgoing Secretary-General (2022–2025)

The valedictory address was delivered by Peter Kwasi Kodjie, Outgoing Secretary-General of the All-Africa Students Union, marking the conclusion of his second tenure covering the period 2022–2025. In his address, the Secretary-General reflected on the administration's focus on institutional consolidation, strategic alignment, and the strengthening of AASU's role as a credible continental student organisation.

He highlighted the administration's efforts to reinforce AASU's mandate through improved governance frameworks, clearer strategic direction, and enhanced operational discipline. Particular emphasis was placed on aligning the Union's work around seven strategic priority areas, which provided coherence for programme implementation, advocacy, and partnerships during the period under review. This strategic realignment enabled AASU to transition from ad hoc interventions to more structured, programme-driven engagements across the continent.

The Outgoing Secretary-General further outlined progress made in strengthening partnerships with continental and international institutions, including closer engagement with African Union bodies, development partners, and higher education stakeholders. These partnerships, he noted, enhanced AASU's visibility, policy relevance, and capacity to contribute meaningfully to discussions on education reform, student participation, climate action, gender advocacy, and governance.

In acknowledging institutional support, Mr. Kodjie expressed deep appreciation to the Government and People of the Republic of Ghana for their continued hosting of the AASU Continental Secretariat and for providing an enabling environment for the Union's operations. He also recognised the support received from other African governments and partner institutions that contributed to the Union's stability and programme delivery during the 2022–2025 period.

In his closing remarks, the Outgoing Secretary-General called on the incoming leadership to uphold unity, collective responsibility, and institutional integrity. He emphasised the importance of continuity, adaptability, and proactive engagement in responding to the evolving challenges facing African students, particularly within a global context increasingly shaping education systems and youth participation. He concluded by expressing confidence in the capacity of the new leadership to build upon the foundations laid and to advance AASU's mission in service of African students.

2.2 Induction and Swearing-In of the New AASU Leadership (2026–2029)

The induction and swearing-in ceremony marked the formal transition of leadership within the All-Africa Students Union for the 2026–2029 term. This segment of the programme constituted the official transfer of authority from the outgoing Executive Committee to the newly elected leadership, in accordance with the Union's constitutional provisions.

The administration of the oath of office was facilitated by the Deputy Director of the Africa Bilateral Bureau at the Ministry of Foreign Affairs, Mr. Wilson Adja-Kwesi, representing the Honourable Minister for Foreign Affairs. The conduct of the oath by the Ministry's representative underscored the recognition of AASU as a legitimate continental student body and reflected the longstanding institutional relationship between the Union and the Government of Ghana.

Following the oath administration, the members of the newly inducted Executive Committee were formally presented to the audience. The new leadership for the 2026–2029 term is composed as follows:



Enyinnaya Osikenyi Osisiogu
President
Nigeria



Divine Edem Kwadzodeh
Secretary-General
Ghana



Maravilha Kapaia
Deputy President
Angola



Alistar Pfunye
Deputy Secretary-General
Zimbabwe



Jaber Maataoui
Vice President
for North Africa
Morocco



Rosália Djedjo
Vice President
for West Africa
Guinea-Bissau



Crésence Naomie Mban-ny Valentine Mugun Chepkoech
Vice President
for Central Africa
Cameroon



Valentini Mugun Chepkoech
Vice President
for East Africa
Kenya



Buthanani Thobela
Vice President
for Southern Africa
South Africa



Habiba Mohamed Abdallah
Executive Committee
Member for North Africa
Egypt



Oumu Sall
Executive Committee
Member for West Africa
Liberia



Benita Ndokolo Mfuke
Executive Committee
Member for Central Africa
DR Congo



Stellah Akur Garang
Executive Committee
Member for East Africa
South Sudan



Esther Gomani
Executive Committee
Member for Southern Africa
Malawi



Ben-Christ Trésor Saisonou
Secretary for Education &
Students' Rights
Benin



Amadou B. Jobarteh
Secretary for Press
& Information
The Gambia



Boago Dodo Chingapani
Secretary for Gender &
Affirmative Action
Botswana



Vanessa Kokoe Ajavon
Secretary for Finance
and Administration
Togo

The induction ceremony signified the formal assumption of responsibility by the new Executive Committee and affirmed their mandate to lead the Union in advancing its objectives across the continent. The occasion reinforced AASU's commitment to orderly leadership transition, institutional continuity, and accountable governance within the African student movement.

2.3 Inaugural Address by the Incoming Secretary-General

The inaugural address was delivered by Divine Edem Kwadzodeh, following the formal induction of the new Executive Committee for the 2026–2029 term. In his remarks, the newly sworn in Secretary-General expressed appreciation to the Government and People of the Republic of Ghana for their continued hosting of the AASU Continental Secretariat and for the institutional support extended to the Union over the years.

He outlined a leadership vision anchored in the principle of an “unapologetically Pan-African” student movement, one that remains firmly committed to advancing the collective interests of African students while engaging constructively with governments, higher education institutions, and continental bodies. Emphasising continuity, he acknowledged the foundations laid by the outgoing administration and reaffirmed the new leadership's intention to consolidate gains rather than pursue abrupt institutional shifts.

The Secretary-General highlighted the importance of practical student leadership, noting that the effectiveness of AASU would be measured not by symbolism alone, but by its ability to translate advocacy into tangible outcomes for students across the continent. He stressed the need to deepen collaboration with African universities, regional organisations, and the African Union, particularly in areas relating to education reform, student participation in governance, and youth development.

In concluding his address, Mr. Kwadzodeh underscored that leadership within AASU should be understood as a collective mandate rather than a personal achievement. He called on members of the new Executive Committee to serve with humility, accountability, and unity of purpose, and to remain responsive to the evolving needs of African students within a rapidly changing global education landscape.

2.4 Special Keynote Address

The ceremony also featured keynote remarks by Julian Mawusi Cobbinah, Board Chairperson of the National Youth Authority (NYA) and Director of the Regional Analytics Center for Intelligence (RACI) at the National Security Secretariat, Ghana.

In his address, Mr. Cobbinah reflected on the evolving nature of student activism, noting that contemporary student movements now operate within a more complex national, regional, and global environment shaped by technology, geopolitics, economic pressures, and security considerations. He emphasised that while the principles of advocacy and mobilisation remain central, modern student leadership must increasingly be grounded in knowledge, analysis, and strategic engagement.

He underscored that knowledge has become a critical currency in all engagements, stressing that effective student advocacy today requires intellectual depth, policy literacy, and the ability to contribute meaningfully to discourse beyond protest and mobilisation. According to him, credibility, evidence-based engagement, and informed dialogue are essential for students to remain relevant partners in governance, development, and reform processes.

Mr. Cobbinah further encouraged student leaders to be innovative and forward-looking, urging them to recognise their capacity to shape conversations not only at the institutional and national levels, but also within regional and global platforms. He challenged the new AASU leadership to position African students as contributors to solutions, capable of influencing policy debates on education, development, and youth empowerment.

In tracing the historical evolution of the student movement, he provided an overview of how student activism has transformed over time, from its roots in anti-colonial struggles and democratic agitation to its present role in policy engagement, governance discourse, and institutional reform. He noted that this evolution reflects both changing societal contexts and the growing responsibility placed on student leadership to engage constructively with state and international actors.

The keynote remarks reinforced the importance of intellectual leadership, innovation, and strategic positioning in sustaining the relevance of student movements, and resonated strongly with the overall theme of the ceremony, which emphasised students as partners in reform and delivery.

3.0 HONOURS, CITATIONS AND SPECIAL RECOGNITIONS

A key component of the Handing-Over, Inauguration and Honours Ceremony was the formal recognition of individuals and institutions whose service, leadership, and support have contributed significantly to the advancement of the All-Africa Students Union and the broader African student movement.

3.1 Posthumous and Honorary Recognition – Mr Varney Alieu Jarsey

The ceremony observed a solemn moment of silence in honour of the immediate former President of the All-Africa Students Union, Mr Varney Alieu Jarsey, in recognition of his contribution to the Union and to student leadership on the continent. A citation was presented posthumously, and the honour was received on behalf of the family by Mr. James Washington, President of the Liberia Students Union.

3.2 Service Recognition – Mr Peter Kwasi Kodjie

In recognition of exemplary leadership and dedicated service, a citation of appreciation was presented to Peter Kwasi Kodjie, Outgoing Secretary-General of AASU, acknowledging his contributions during the 2022–2025 period and his broader role in strengthening the Union's institutional governance, partnerships, and strategic orientation.

3.3 Institutional Appreciation – Government of Ghana

A citation was presented to the Government and People of the Republic of Ghana in appreciation of their longstanding commitment to Pan-Africanism and for hosting the AASU Continental Secretariat in Accra, thereby providing an enabling environment for the Union's continental operations and diplomatic engagement.

4.0 ANNOUNCEMENT OF THE AASU ADVISORY BOARD

As part of the institutional strengthening measures accompanying the new leadership term, the ceremony also featured the formal announcement of the AASU Advisory Board. The establishment of the Advisory Board is intended to provide strategic guidance, policy insight, and high-level counsel to the Executive Committee, while strengthening AASU's engagement with governments, diplomatic institutions, and continental bodies.

The announced composition of the Advisory Board is as follows:

Name	Designation / Affiliation	Role on Board
Mr Peter Kwasi Kodjie	Former Secretary-General, AASU; Chairman, SOS International (UK)	Member
Mr Divine Edem Kwadzodeh	Secretary-General, All-Africa Students Union	Secretary
H. E. Imane Ouadil	Ambassador of the Kingdom of Morocco to the Republic of Ghana; Dean of the Diplomatic Corps	Member
Mr Nicholas Ouma	Principal Officer, Higher Education and TVET, African Union Commission	Member
Dr Osman Tahidu Damba	Secretary-General, Ghana Commission for UNESCO	Member
Representative of Angola	To be nominated	Member
Ms Mavis Lamisi Apeliba	Technical Advisor to the Minister, Ministry of Youth Development and Empowerment	Member
Ministry of Foreign Affairs – Ghana Nominee	To be confirmed	Member
Nominee of the President of the Republic of Ghana	To be confirmed	Chairman

5.0 PRESIDENTIAL ADDRESS AND REFLECTIONS

Following the announcement of the Advisory Board and the conferment of honours, the newly inaugurated President of the All-Africa Students Union, Enyinnaya Osikenye Osisiogu, delivered his presidential address to the assembly.

In his remarks, the President expressed appreciation to the Government and People of the Republic of Ghana for their continued support to the Union and for hosting the AASU Continental Secretariat. He acknowledged the Ministry of Foreign Affairs for facilitating the ceremony and for its role in supporting AASU's institutional legitimacy and continental engagement.

The President paid tribute to the outgoing leadership for the foundations laid during the previous administration, noting that the progress achieved in governance, partnerships, and programme delivery set a high standard for the new Executive Committee. He emphasised that the incoming leadership viewed its mandate as one of continuity and consolidation, rather than departure from established institutional principles.

Reflecting on the role of AASU within the broader African context, the President reaffirmed the Union's commitment to Pan-Africanism, student solidarity, and constructive engagement with governments and continental institutions. He underscored the importance of positioning students as credible stakeholders in education reform, governance, and development processes, and highlighted the need for unity across regional, linguistic, and national divides within the African student movement.

In concluding his address, the President pledged that the 2026–2029 administration would prioritise institutional discipline, partnership management, and inclusive leadership. He called on students across the continent to actively engage with the Union's programmes and advocacy efforts, and expressed confidence that, with sustained collaboration and accountability, AASU would continue to strengthen its role as a representative voice for African students.

6.0 CLOSING SESSION AND ADJOURNMENT

The closing session of the Handing-Over, Inauguration and Honours Ceremony provided an opportunity for final reflections and formal conclusion of proceedings. Brief closing remarks were delivered by the President of the National Association of Nigerian Students (NANS), who acknowledged the successful transition of leadership within the All-Africa Students Union and commended the collective efforts of the outgoing and incoming leadership, partners, and stakeholders in advancing student welfare and academic stability across the continent.

The ceremony was then brought to a close with a closing prayer led by Benita Ndokolo Mfuke, Executive Committee Member for Central Africa, invoking guidance and success for the newly inaugurated leadership and for the continued work of the Union.

Following the prayer, the Master of Ceremonies, Mr. Samuel Sasu Adonteng, formally adjourned the ceremony, marking the official conclusion of the programme. The event concluded with a brief networking interaction and a group photo session to commemorate the inauguration of the new AASU leadership and the beginning of a new administrative term.

7.0 PARTICIPATION AND ATTENDANCE

The Handing-Over, Inauguration and Honours Ceremony of the All-Africa Students Union recorded strong continental and multi-stakeholder participation, reflecting the Union's reach, relevance, and institutional standing within Africa's education and youth engagement landscape.

The event was attended by over 500 participants drawn from across the African continent, including representatives of national student unions, regional student bodies, youth organisations, civil society institutions, and development partners. The wide participation underscored AASU's role as a convening platform for African students and its capacity to mobilise diverse stakeholders around issues of education, governance, and youth development.

Government representation featured prominently, with officials from the Ministry of Foreign Affairs, other public institutions, and allied agencies in attendance. Members of the diplomatic corps, representatives of international and continental organisations, and officials from partner institutions further contributed to the high-level profile of the ceremony. Their presence reinforced the importance of student movements as legitimate stakeholders in national and continental policy dialogue.

The AASU Secretariat and staff were fully represented, alongside outgoing and incoming members of the Executive Committee. Former student leaders and institutional partners also attended, providing continuity and historical perspective to the transition process.

Overall, the level and diversity of participation demonstrated broad support for the leadership transition and reaffirmed the confidence of stakeholders in AASU's mandate, governance structures, and future direction. The strong turnout further highlighted Ghana's role as a trusted host and diplomatic hub for Pan-African student engagement.

8.0 KEY OUTCOMES AND SIGNIFICANCE

The Handing-Over, Inauguration and Honours Ceremony yielded several important outcomes that are significant for the institutional development of the All-Africa Students Union (AASU) and for its relationship with the Government of Ghana and other stakeholders.

First, the ceremony successfully effected an orderly and transparent transition of leadership from the outgoing Executive Committee to the newly elected leadership for the 2026–2029 term, in line with AASU's constitutional provisions. The formal administration of the oath of office by the representative of the Ministry of Foreign Affairs reinforced the legitimacy of the new leadership and underscored the institutional recognition accorded to AASU.

Second, the event reaffirmed AASU's strategic direction and mandate as a continental student organisation committed to positioning students as constructive partners in education reform, governance, and development. Through the valedictory, inaugural, keynote, and presidential addresses, the ceremony articulated continuity of purpose while signalling renewed focus on innovation, policy engagement, and accountable leadership.

Third, the recognition of individuals and institutions through honours and citations strengthened institutional memory and acknowledged the contributions of partners who have supported AASU's work over the years. The institutional appreciation extended to the Government of Ghana highlighted the enduring partnership that has enabled AASU to operate effectively from its Continental Secretariat in Accra.

Fourth, the announcement of the AASU Advisory Board marked a significant step toward enhanced governance and strategic oversight. The composition of the Board, bringing together experience from diplomacy, education policy, youth development, and continental institutions, signals AASU's intention to deepen strategic guidance, policy coherence, and stakeholder engagement under the new administration.

Finally, the strong participation of over 500 stakeholders from across the continent demonstrated broad confidence in AASU's leadership, relevance, and convening power, while reinforcing Ghana's role as a hub for Pan-African student engagement and diplomacy.

9.0 CONCLUSION

The Handing-Over, Inauguration and Honours Ceremony of the All-Africa Students Union marked a pivotal moment in the Union's institutional life, bringing together continuity, renewal, and recognition within a single, well-coordinated programme. Convened at the Press Centre of the Ministry of Foreign Affairs, the ceremony reflected the depth of partnership between AASU and the Government of Ghana and underscored the Union's standing as a credible continental stakeholder.

As AASU embarks on the 2026–2029 leadership term, the outcomes of the ceremony provide a strong foundation for sustained engagement with governments, continental bodies, development partners, and student constituencies across Africa. The Union remains committed to advancing students' rights, strengthening student participation in policy and governance processes, and contributing meaningfully to Africa's education transformation.

The All-Africa Students Union expresses its appreciation to the Ministry of Foreign Affairs for hosting and facilitating the ceremony, and to all partners and stakeholders whose participation contributed to its success. The Union looks forward to continued collaboration in pursuit of shared objectives for Africa's students and the continent's future.



Ministry of Foreign Affairs
Republic of Ghana

AASU INAUGURATION AND HONOURS CEREMONY 2026

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